

Trust gap Widens

AS NOEL TATA AND VENU SRINIVASAN SLUG IT OUT ON MULTIPLE ISSUES, THE ROAD AHEAD FOR THE LISTING OF TATA SONS REMAINS UNCERTAIN

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ILLUSTRATION BY NILANJAN DAS

THE LISTING OF Tata Sons, the holding company of the Tata Group, has another layer of complexity to it now. Noel Tata, Chairman, Tata Trusts, is not in agreement with Venu Srinivasan, Chairman Emeritus, TVS Motor, and Vijay Singh, former Defence Secretary (both are also Vice-Chairmen, Tata Trusts), on the listing issue.

Tata Trusts controls over two-third of Tata Sons. Tata and Srinivasan are the trust's nominees on the board of the Tata Group. One-third of the board is accounted for by the trusts. Tata and Srinivasan are the nominees, with a spate of developments in the recent past confirming the already fractious relationship. Media reports cited

how Tata did not vote in favour of Srinivasan's continuation as a trustee on the Tata Education and Development Trust (TEDT). Singh's reappointment also did not go through.

A new set of rules in the Maharashtra Public Trusts (Amendment) Ordinance, 2025, has mandated that all appointments and reappointments have to be unanimous, unlike the earlier practice, which led to Srinivasan resigning from TEDT. This was preceded by his having to leave the board of Bai Hirabai Jamshetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution, when his position was questioned by former Tata Trustee, Mehli Mistry, on the grounds of Srinivasan not belonging to the Zoroastrian faith and not permanently residing in Mumbai.

REACHING A FLASHPOINT

Another critical issue was the reappointment of Srinivasan and Singh on boards of Sir Ratan Tata Trust and Sir Dorabji Trust, which hold over 51% of Tata Trusts.

The meeting for this was to be held on May 8, then deferred to May 16. Meanwhile, a complaint was filed by Katyayani Agarwal, an advocate, who said three of the six trustees at Sir Ratan Tata Trust are "permanent in nature", in contravention of Section 30A (2) of the Maharashtra Public Trusts Act, 1950, which pegs the proportion at one-fourth.

Of the six trustees, three have a permanent position—Jimmy N Tata, Ratan Tata's younger brother, Noel Tata and Jehangir H.C. Jehangir, Chairman of Pune's Jehangir Hospital. The other three—Srinivasan, Singh and senior advocate Darius Khambata—have a fixed tenure.

Agarwal sought the Charity Commissioner's intervention on the matter. "The composition must change once the amendment is in effect," Agarwal told *BT*, before making it clear that the complaint was, for the moment, restricted to Sir Ratan Tata Trust. A Tata Trusts